

Chapter 15

The First Clue

The next morning...

Roman woke earlier than usual.

He had barely slept.

His mind kept returning to the same thing.

Noah's phone.

He got dressed and left his apartment without breakfast.

By the time he reached his office, the city was already awake.

Employees moved through the corridors.

Phones rang.

Doors opened and closed.

Everything looked normal.

But Roman couldn't focus on any of it.

He walked into his office and placed his phone on the desk.

A few minutes later...

his investigator called.

"Sir."

Roman immediately answered.

"Tell me."

"We've recovered something."

Roman straightened.

"How much?"

"Not much."

A pause.

"But enough to be interesting."

Roman's expression changed.

"Come to my office."

"Already on my way."

Ten minutes later...

the investigator entered Roman's office carrying a laptop.

Roman closed the door.

"Show me."

The investigator opened the laptop.

"The phone was badly damaged, so we couldn't recover everything."

Roman nodded.

"What did you get?"

"Some deleted files."

"Messages?"

"Fragments."

Roman leaned closer.

The investigator opened a recovered folder.

Several files appeared.

Most were corrupted.

Some wouldn't open.

Then one message appeared.

Roman stared at the screen.

ETHAN: We need to talk before she tells anyone.

Roman's eyes narrowed.

"Who's she?"

"We don't know yet."

Another fragment appeared.

NOAH: You can't keep asking me to lie for you.

Roman stopped breathing for a second.

The investigator looked at him.

"Sir..."

Roman didn't answer.

Another message appeared.

ETHAN: Just give me time.

Then the file ended.

Roman leaned back slowly.

Noah.

Ethan.

Lies.

His suspicion had just become something much more serious.

"Can you recover more?"

"We're trying."

Roman looked at the screen again.

"Don't rush it."

The investigator nodded.

Roman closed the laptop.

"And I want everything connected to Ethan checked."

"His movements?"

"Everything."

The investigator hesitated.

"Do you want me to approach him?"

"No."

Roman's voice became firm.

"Don't let him know we're looking."

Later that afternoon...

Roman stood near the window of his office.

His phone vibrated.

A message from Elara.

Elara:

Did they find anything?

Roman stared at the message.

His fingers moved across the keyboard.

He typed:

Roman:

Something.

Elara replied almost immediately.

Elara:

What?

Roman paused.

He remembered the promise he had made.

He didn't want to give her half a truth and make her believe the rest.

So he typed:

Roman:

I'm still trying to understand it.

A few seconds later...

Elara:

Is it bad?

Roman looked toward the recovered files on his laptop.

Then replied:

Roman:

I don't know yet.

He put the phone down.

But before he could return to work...

another message appeared.

Elara:

Then don't face it alone.

Roman stared at those words.

A faint smile appeared on his face.

He typed:

Roman:

I'm trying not to.

Then he locked the phone.

That evening...

the investigator followed Ethan from a distance.

Ethan left his office later than usual.

He got into his car.

The investigator followed only long enough to confirm his destination.

A private restaurant on the outskirts of the city.

Ethan entered alone.

Twenty minutes later...

another car arrived.

A man stepped out.

Older.

Well dressed.

Calm.

The investigator recognized him immediately.

Ethan's father.

A powerful politician with years of influence behind him.

He had appeared in newspapers countless times.

Public speeches.

Political meetings.

Business events.

A man known for having connections in places most people never saw.

The investigator stayed in his car.

He didn't approach.

Instead...

he waited.

Through the restaurant's glass entrance, he watched Ethan and his father sit together.

Their conversation appeared tense.

The investigator quietly started recording from a safe distance where the conversation could be captured without him entering the restaurant.

Not every word was clear.

But some were.

Ethan's father leaned forward.

Ethan looked nervous.

Then his father said something that made Ethan suddenly look away.

The investigator continued recording.

A few minutes later...

Ethan left.

His father remained inside.

The investigator stopped the recording.

He immediately sent the video to Roman.

I think you need to see this.

Roman opened the file.

He watched it once.

Then again.

His expression became serious.

He didn't upload it anywhere.

Not yet.

He knew a fragment without context could destroy innocent people too.

First...

he needed the complete truth.

He sent one message back.

Keep following the evidence.

Then he closed the video.

Outside his office window...

the city lights flickered beneath the night sky.

Roman looked at Noah's recovered messages again.

One name kept appearing.

Ethan.

For the first time...

Roman wasn't searching blindly anymore.

He had a direction.

And somewhere ahead...

the truth was waiting.